

Data Classification and Handling Policy

Version 1.0 | Owner: Security Operations | Effective 2026-01-01 | Next review 2027-01-01

1. Purpose

Not all information carries the same risk if it is lost or disclosed. This policy classifies Zuqah Technologies data into four levels and describes how each level must be handled, stored, shared and disposed of.

Every employee who creates, receives or works with company data is responsible for handling it according to its classification.

2. Classification levels

Level	Label	Description	Examples
1	Public	Information intentionally released for public consumption	Website content, published press releases, published job adverts
2	Internal	Information for internal use; disclosure would be mildly embarrassing or inconvenient but not harmful	Internal newsletters, general process documents, team meeting notes
3	Confidential	Sensitive information; disclosure could harm the business, partners or individuals	Client contracts, employee salaries, business strategy, source code, HR records, financial data
4	Restricted	Highest sensitivity; disclosure could cause serious harm	Personal data of a sensitive nature (health, financial), client credentials, security infrastructure details, data covered by NDA

When in doubt, classify one level higher.

3. Handling rules by classification

3.1 Storage

Level	Approved storage
Public	Any approved platform
Internal	Company-approved cloud storage (OneDrive, SharePoint) or company systems only
Confidential	Company-approved cloud storage with appropriate access controls; do not store on local drives without backup
Restricted	Approved systems with role-based access controls, encryption at rest; no local copies

Personal cloud storage (Google Drive, Dropbox, personal OneDrive) must never be used for Internal, Confidential or Restricted data.

3.2 Sharing internally

Level	Requirement
Public	No restriction
Internal	Share via company channels only (email, Teams); confirm the recipient needs the information
Confidential	Share on a need-to-know basis; use permissions on shared files rather than sending copies
Restricted	Explicit approval from the data owner before sharing; log who has access

3.3 Sharing externally

Level	Requirement
Public	Fine to share
Internal	Do not share externally without manager approval
Confidential	Share only under a signed NDA; use encrypted transfer methods; manager approval required
Restricted	Share only with explicit sign-off from a Director or above; encrypted transfer mandatory; record the disclosure

3.4 Encryption and transmission

- Confidential and Restricted data in transit must be encrypted. Use secure file transfer links (SharePoint, OneDrive with link expiry) rather than email attachments for Confidential data
- Never send Restricted data by email attachment without password-protecting the file and sharing the password by a separate channel
- Do not transmit Restricted data by SMS, WhatsApp or personal email under any circumstances

3.5 Printing

- Internal: may be printed for legitimate business purposes; dispose of in secure shredding bins
- Confidential and Restricted: do not print unless there is a specific operational need; if printed, the document must be collected immediately from the printer and stored or shredded securely. Do not leave on a printer tray unattended

3.6 Disposal

Level	Disposal method
Public / Internal	Regular recycle bin (digital); shredding bin (physical)
Confidential	Secure deletion (see IT for secure erase tools); cross-cut shredding for paper
Restricted	Verified secure deletion with IT confirmation; cross-cut shredding; IT must be notified

"Deleting" a file in Windows or macOS does not securely erase it. Contact IT for the approved secure deletion tool.

4. Personal data

All personal data (data from which a living individual can be identified) must be treated as Confidential as a minimum, and as Restricted where the data falls into a sensitive category (health, financial, political opinions, religion, biometric data).

See the Employee Data Privacy Policy for full details.

5. Client data

Client data must be classified at the level agreed in the client contract. Where no classification is specified, treat it as Confidential as a minimum. Client data may never be used for any purpose other than delivering the contracted service.

6. How to label data

Documents, files and emails that contain Confidential or Restricted information should include the classification label in the filename, document header or email subject where practical.

Example: [CONFIDENTIAL] Q3 Financials — Draft.xlsx

7. Breaches

Any suspected breach of this policy — data sent to the wrong person, a device containing classified data lost, a file shared beyond its intended audience — must be reported immediately to security@zuqahtechnologies.com.

Early reporting limits harm and is not penalised. Deliberate or grossly negligent breaches of this policy are a disciplinary matter.

8. Contact

Classification queries: security@zuqahtechnologies.com

Secure file transfer assistance: it@zuqahtechnologies.com

Sample content for demonstration purposes. Zuqah Technologies is a fictional company and this document describes no real organisation's policy.